

While notions of war could be both romantic and ridiculous, a genuine undercurrent of fierce patriotism motivated many volunteers. One Union soldier explained in a letter that he enlisted because “I performed but a simple duty—a duty to my country and myself ... to give up life if need be ... in this battle for freedom and right, opposed to slavery and wrong.” A Southern volunteer reflected many others’ views when he said, “I would give all I have got just to be in the front rank of the first brigade that marches against the invading foe who now pollute the sacred soil of my native state [Virginia] with their unholy tread.” This patriotism would help sustain both armies’ fighting abilities through a long and difficult war, but it also tended to denigrate the importance of professional competence and discipline. Both armies paid too little attention to the warnings of prewar professional soldiers that troops needed training and discipline to be effective, and that the coming conflict might be long and grueling.